

Economy Governed Change: A View from Basque Auxiliaries

All Basque dialects of the Archaic period (XV-XVIth century) seem to have shared a number of properties regarding the form and distribution of auxiliaries, which are kept (in a somewhat reduced fashion) only in eastern dialects today. Those properties can be summarized as follows: (i) Optional object and dative agreement (1-2); (ii) main predicate status of *be* and *have* (3); (iii) independent lexical forms for those same auxiliaries, that allow for verbal nominalization (4); (iv) sequences of the type *wh-/foc auxiliary* (5); (v) *be* auxiliaries with transitive predicates (6); and (vi) sequences in which the aspectual complement and the auxiliary are separated by something else, either negation or an additive marker of the *even/also* sort (7). I will claim that those properties can be captured on the basis of a single morphosyntactic parameter, consisting in the fact that Archaic Basque copulas were “synthetic verbs” (De Rijk, 2008), not auxiliaries (understood as the mere lexicalization of T/Agr). Synthetic verbs are finite verbs which, unlike auxiliaries, possess a lexical root. The class of synthetic verbs in Basque is composed of a handful of very common verbs, including the equivalents of the romance locative copulas (cf. Spanish *estar*). In the period known as Archaic Basque, this class would include the transitive and intransitive auxiliaries. As a first step in the argument, let me note that the immediate adjacency of focus/*wh*-phrase and finite forms is (and was) generally possible in Basque in the case of synthetic verbs (8), and in identificational predications (9), for which it has been claimed that the copula may be a contentful verb (e.g. Zaring, 1996, on Welsh). This hypothesis complies well with the fact that XVIth century Basque had distinct lexical forms for intransitive (*izan*) and transitive (*edun*) auxiliaries in non-finite contexts, as well as with the fact that *be* and *have* could constitute the main predicate of the clause. We can capitalize on the lexical status of the copulas to account for the rest of the distinguishing properties of early Basque dialects: on the one hand, lexical copulas do not trigger ordinary predicate fronting (Haddican, 2004, 2008), the syntactic process whereby verbal predicates in Basque periphrases raise to a higher polarity phrase immediately preceding the auxiliary in unmarked affirmative sentences, yielding the rigid sequence OVAux. Other things, such as focus particles or negation, could intervene (7). The intransitive auxiliary in (6) is reminiscent of Laka’s (2006) discussion of ergative splits in the context of progressive periphrases. Those cases can be accounted for as instances in which the lexical auxiliary selects a full non-finite clause, whose silent subject is controlled by the matrix subject, and which has the necessary functional structure to license object case. Finally, if lexical verbs can take complements of different complexity (Wurmbrandt, 2004), it is natural to conclude that the highest expansion of the non-finite complement (say T –closest probe- or C/T- a phase) may block dative and/or object agreement. Eastern dialects have kept a number of the properties that characterize Archaic Basque: they have optional dative agreement, main predicate *be* and *have*, different lexical entries for each of the auxiliaries (*izan* “be” and *ukan* “have”), optional sequences of *wh-/foc auxiliary*, and sequences of the type *AspP Particle Aux*. Modern eastern dialects have also kept intransitive auxiliaries for unergative verbs (10), although full transitive clauses with *be* (6) are not possible anymore. The fact that (10) is possible but that (6) is not anymore in present-day Eastern dialects invites the conclusion that the complement selected by the auxiliary is simpler. One possibility is that Aux is generated in an aspectual head, not on V, and that it takes a vP as its complement. Following Fernandez (1997), I will argue that Eastern vP complements project a case licensing head F. F licenses one of the arguments of a transitive verb, typically the object. In the case of transitive predicates, this will force the subject to raise outside the participial clause, ending up in a local relation with the higher T ((11a), see Rezac et al., 2014). An

exception arises in the context of unergatives if incorporation of the bare noun (*dantza*) to V allows it to dispense with case (Baker, 1988). In that case, the case feature in the participial is available for the second argument (the subject), which does not raise and surfaces as absolutive (11b). The evolution of verbal periphrases can be viewed as a diachronic process whereby biclausal periphrases became monoclausal in Basque (Mounole, 2012). This process was accomplished in western/central areas, but did not fully affect eastern varieties. The transition involves the grammaticalization of *be* and *have* from verbal categories (Archaic Basque) to Asp heads (Eastern varieties) to T/Agr. A general exception to this process is provided by non-verbal predication, where a lexical copula is general for all dialects. That is, in contexts in which the predicate is not a verb, and the presence of a copula becomes necessary for predication (Baker, 2003), finite auxiliaries behave everywhere as Eastern ones. *Wh-/foc Aux* orders, for instance, are the rule for non-verbal predication (12). Rooted auxiliaries are thus retained when they would save the derivation from crashing. The split between verbal and non-verbal predication invites the conclusion that a principle of representational economy grounded in the acquisition device guides the learner in the grammaticalization process (Roussou and Roberts' *Representational Economy* (2003); Van Gelderen's *Late Merge*, (2011).

- (1) Pelicanoac amorioz umeak daguidanean **No Obj agreement**
Pellican.ERG love.by offspring.PL does.SING.when
"When the pelican produces offspring for the sake of love" (XVIth c.)
- (2) Oi aldioneri albanegi enpara **No Dative agreement**
Oh this.occasion.DAT if.I.could.do escape
"Oh, if I could escape this occasion" (XVth c.)
- (3) a. Ate arte zabalean ohi **zan** b. Zaldibarrek bere partea **debala**
door space wide.in Asp was Zaldibar.ERG his share has.COMP
"She used to stand in the wide entrance" "Let Zaldibar have his share" (XVth)
- (4) Atsein handia da amore **eutea** (5) Gatx txipiak nau ikaratzten...
pleasure big is love to.have.NOM Harm small.ERG aux frighten
"It is a big pleasure to have love" "SMALL DAMAGES frighten me"
- (6) Beste amore bilatuco **nax** (7) a. Ydoro ez eban
other love find.Asp I.am found neg he/she.had
"I will find another lover" "He/she didn't find it"
- (8) Nor dator? (General) (9) Nor da hori? (General)
Who comes Who is this
- (10) Dantzatu naiz (Eastern) (11) a. [TP DP T_{AUX}... [vP(DP) v V+N]]
danced I.am _____/ (Ergative Case/Agr)
"I have danced" b. [TP T... V_{BE} [PartP DP F⁰ [vP (DP) v V+N]]
_____/ (Absolutive agreement)
- (12) a. Nor duzu gogoko? b. *Nor gogoko duzu? c. Gogoko duzu
who you.have likeable who likeable you.have likeable you.have
"Who do you like?" "You like him/her"